

MIG-13

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-13

Age: 27

Gender: Female

Country of origin: Brazil

Host country: Spain

Years in host country: 3

Occupation: Hospitality Worker

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to Spain three years ago seeking better opportunities and a genuine fresh start after struggling for a long time to find stable, decent work in Brazil despite my best efforts. Spain's culture felt somewhat familiar to me, and the language was considerably easier to learn given its close similarity to Portuguese, which made the prospect far less daunting than moving somewhere completely foreign. I also wanted adventure and a measure of economic stability that had eluded me at home, so I took a real chance on Europe, arriving with limited savings and a great deal of hope. The reality has been a mix of genuine opportunity and unexpected difficulty, but I have not regretted the decision to try to build something new for myself here.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being treated as an equal by my Spanish coworkers and employers, rather than as disposable, easily-replaced labour whose particular humanity does not much matter. It shows itself when local people appreciate what I bring to the workplace and the community rather than seeing me primarily as unwanted competition for jobs or as an outsider who has taken something that belonged to others. Belonging, for me, is the feeling that Spain can genuinely become my home over time, a place where I have a real future, a stable footing, and a community that accepts me, rather than a place where I am always slightly provisional, tolerated as long as I am useful but never fully embraced as one of its own.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: There is definitely xenophobia toward Latin American migrants here, sometimes expressed subtly and sometimes quite openly and directly. I have heard plenty of comments about immigrants taking jobs from Spaniards and depressing wages, and I have been treated dismissively and condescendingly because of my accent, which immediately marks me as foreign. As a Brazilian woman specifically, I also face uncomfortable and persistent stereotypes and a certain objectification, assumptions about what Brazilian women are supposedly like, which adds another painful and demeaning layer to the prejudice I already experience simply as a migrant. Being reduced in strangers' eyes to a set of tired

clichés, rather than seen as an individual, is genuinely wearing over time.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The main challenges were the legal hurdles involved in obtaining proper work authorisation and secure residency, a process that took time and caused me a great deal of anxiety about my future and my right to remain. Although Spanish was indeed easier to learn than a completely unrelated language would have been, the cultural differences turned out to be more significant than I had expected, and building a social network entirely from scratch, without any existing connections, was harder and lonelier than I had anticipated. Finding stable, fairly-paid work within the hospitality sector, which is notorious for precarious conditions and low pay, was also a constant and ongoing struggle that has yet to fully resolve itself.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: In the hospitality industry the workforce is genuinely diverse, with a great many immigrants from all over, so I have found real camaraderie and solidarity among fellow migrants who understand exactly what I am going through. Some of my Spanish colleagues are warm, friendly, and welcoming, treating me as one of the team, while others keep their distance and remain somewhat cool. My current workplace is decent enough, though the industry as a whole can be exploitative, with long hours and insecure contracts. The solidarity among immigrant workers, the sense that we are all in a similar situation and can support one another, genuinely helps me to endure the tougher conditions and the occasional hostility.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I keep my Brazilian spirit and identity alive through music and dance, which are so central to who I am and which lift my spirits, through cooking the dishes of home, and through connecting with the Brazilian community here in Spain, which provides a comforting sense of familiarity. At the same time, I have genuinely embraced many Spanish customs and the overall lifestyle, and I have grown to love aspects of life here, the rhythms of the day, the food, the sociability. I feel proudly and unmistakably Brazilian while steadily adapting to my new home, blending both cultures together in my daily life in a way that feels natural rather than forced, taking the best of each.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: Spanish media sometimes portrays Latin American immigrants through unflattering stereotypes, and Brazilian women in particular are frequently objectified in problematic and demeaning ways that reflect and reinforce broader prejudices. This kind of representation directly shapes how people treat me in daily life, sometimes reducing me to a stereotype in their minds rather than allowing them to see me as the individual person that I actually am, with my own character, ambitions, and dignity. More respectful, realistic, and varied representation of Latina migrants in the media would genuinely improve how we are perceived and treated, and would help to dismantle some of the assumptions that make ordinary interactions unexpectedly difficult and occasionally humiliating for women like me.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: Integration support was quite limited in my experience, and I relied mostly on the immigrant community itself and on my own resourcefulness and determination to figure things out and find my

footing. There were some NGO resources available that provided legal help and guidance, which proved genuinely useful when I needed to navigate the residency process, and I was grateful for them. But Spain could do considerably more to support the integration of Latin American migrants, who, despite sharing significant cultural and linguistic ties with Spain, still face real and substantial barriers to full inclusion and are too often assumed to need no help simply because of that shared heritage.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: I do not have children, but I do think about the future generation of Latin Americans growing up here in Spain, and I observe them where I can. Many of the children of immigrants here grow up thoroughly Spanish in language and culture, indistinguishable in many ways from their peers, yet they sometimes still face uncomfortable questions about their identity and encounter discrimination that reminds them they are seen as somehow not fully belonging. My hope is that they will come to be embraced as fully Spanish while still being able to honour and take pride in their roots, in a future society that is more genuinely accepting and less prone to treating difference as a deficiency.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, Spain should more fully recognise the cultural and economic contributions of Latin American migrants, who share so much history and so many ties with Spain and who contribute significantly to the economy and society. Actively combating stereotypes, and especially the persistent objectification of Latina women, is crucial and long overdue. And personal connections, as always, dissolve prejudice more effectively than anything else; in my own experience, when Spaniards actually get to know us as individuals, as coworkers and neighbours and friends, the negative assumptions they may have held tend to fade away and are replaced by genuine understanding and, often, real warmth and friendship.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to gain stable, secure residency and perhaps to move beyond hospitality work into a career that offers more security, better pay, and real opportunities for growth and advancement over time. I dream of building a settled, stable life here in Spain, and perhaps one day starting a family of my own on solid ground. I also hope very much to be able to travel back to Brazil regularly, maintaining my close connection to my family and to the homeland that I still cherish deeply, so that in building a future here I do not have to sever my ties to where I came from.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to newcomers is to sort out your legal status as an absolute priority, because it is what protects you from exploitation and gives you access to a genuine and secure life rather than a precarious one. Take the time to learn the local nuances and cultural expectations even when the language itself seems familiar and easy, because the culture can differ more than you expect. Build connections with both fellow immigrants, for support and understanding, and with locals, for integration and belonging. And stay confident in yourself despite the stereotypes you will encounter, and never let anyone reduce you to a prejudiced assumption about your nationality or your gender.